

The Body - The Buddha's World View and the Role of Materiality (Rūpa)

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 42:44

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambhudassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sambha Sambuddhasa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-enlightened one.

So I want to talk about *rūpa* eventually. But before we do that, I thought we'd try to understand these different words that the Buddha uses to describe our condition. He talks about the all, and so I coined a word: his omniscience. And he uses three words to explain this. The first one is *āyatana*, then there's *indriya*, and then there's *dhātu*.

An *āyatana* is a sphere. There are various spheres cosmologically — all these different realms are all spheres. But for us as human beings, they refer basically to these sense bases. And the fact that these sense bases are unique and that they're discrete — you can't mix them. So, for instance, you can't hear through your eyes. And some might say, "Well, what about synesthesia?" You know, where people see colour and they hear this beautiful sound. But that's done by the mind. At the basic level of just that sense base, the retina can only see. It can only be sensitive to photons. It's not sensitive to airwaves. So that's what he means by an *āyatana*. And there are six of them — so there's five, remember, the five senses, and the mind itself as a sense base. So the mind as a sense base is basically for your thoughts and emotions, but it also works as a channel that information comes from the other five and it runs through the sense base of *manā* and into the mind, and then the mind creates something.

And when he's describing *Nibbāna*, of course, he uses this word *āyatana*. It's an *āyatana*, the dimension, the sphere, etc. So that's one thing. So he's always deconstructing and he's always trying to show us where the problem lies. Okay? So the problem lies in the *āyatana* of not recognising that they are discrete, that they don't actually communicate with each other. That's all done through the cleverness, the magic of the mind.

The next one is *indriya*, which means a power, or better still when it comes to the senses, a faculty. It's your faculties. And they're controlling principles. They direct force. So your *cakkhindriya*, your eye *indriya*, your eye faculty, is a way in through this ability to see the world. It's a faculty, it's a power. And actually, there's 22 of them, but we don't want to go into them because it does get a bit strange for us.

On this side here, I'll just run through them so that you see the idea of faculty slightly changes. Here we

are. So there's the first five, of course, are the sense bases, right? So the eye, the ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, the mind. Then you have femininity and masculinity. Those are two different faculties. If you think of them as faculties, powers. Then you have vitality. This word *jīva* is in other traditions often translated as soul, but here it's just translated as vitality. I've never really understood it. Nobody's ever really been able to explain what this vitality is. So I'm just presuming it must be this chi that we work with.

And then there's the whole business of pleasure and pain. So these are powers, if you think of them as powers, the ability to, a faculty. So it's the ability to feel pleasant bodily feelings and bodily pain. Then you get mental good feelings and bad feelings. Here it's translated as gladness and sadness. I don't think that's quite right. And then there's, it's translated as indifference, but it's basically the neutral, when they're all experienced as neutral. So these are also seen as *indriyas*.

Then you have the five spiritual powers, the five spiritual faculties. So that's faith, energy, mindfulness, concentration and wisdom. And then the last three are to do with the process of liberation. The first two, the assurance, "I shall know what I did not know yet." So there's your determination. And that's the achievement of Magga. That's the path of stream entrant. And that is only matured in the next one, the faculty of highest knowledge, which is the fruit. And then the final one is the faculty of the one who knows. That's where we're heading, okay? So you can see there's a way of describing the human being from various different angles — *āyatana*, these powers, and the final one would be *dhātu* or elements.

An element is something beyond which you cannot go. It's your basic experience. And that, of course, brings us to these four *Mahābhūtas*, the four great elements. *Bhūta* actually means the four great beings, but translated also as the *dhātu*, the *cattāro dhātu*, which means the four great elements.

The last thing is this word *loka*. It's another word for *āyatana*, really. Its original thing was space, open spaceness, open space. But it's also used as *loka* — so *devaloka*, the open space where the *devas* live. And this would be the human *loka*. But when he's talking about a spiritual, when he's looking at us from a spiritual angle of liberating from suffering, then the *loka* is referring to our universe. So again, it's recognising that we are entirely dependent upon our senses for our understanding, communication, etc., relationship to the world. So we're constantly creating our own little *loka*, our own little universe. And we're always right there at the centre of it, the sense of self. And that's what he's particularly concerned with.

Because when you hear the Mahāyāna talk about saṃsāra is nirvāṇa, or nirvāṇa is saṃsāra, what they mean is this *loka*, this universe that we're creating, is either going to be suffering for us or not. And that's where the change of relationship to what we're actually experiencing is so important.

So these words just tell us the way that he deconstructed our experience. Really always pointing us to where the problem was. To where the actual work was to be done.

So then going back now to *rūpa*. So *rūpa* is one of the five *khandhas*. That's another way of looking at our. You've got the body, you've got feelings, you've got perception. *Saṅkhāras*, which are translated quite mystically as volitional conditionings. It just means everything that we personally can create through our acts of will. And finally, consciousness. And, of course, he does that to show us that we're all made up of pieces, little bits and pieces, but specifically where the problem lies, which is with *saṅkhāra*.

So if we go back to *rūpa*, that basic place of contact with the world, there's a discourse here which is worth reading and just go through it slowly. And it's called "The Greater Discourse on the Simile of the Elephant's Footprint." And it looks as though to me, I don't know, you have to read the commentaries, it looks as though it's a teaching actually from Sāriputta. So on one occasion, remember that when somebody spoke something and they would tell the Buddha that, you know, someone said this, you know, if he agreed with it, he would say, "Well, if you'd have asked me, I'd have said the same thing."

So he's sitting there now, he says, "Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was living at Sāvatti in Jeta's Grove, in Anāthapiṇḍika's Park, and there the Venerable Sāriputta addressed the *bhikkhus* thus, 'Friends, *bhikkhus*.' 'Friends,' they replied, and the Venerable Sāriputta said this."

Remember that in the commentary where it says *bhikkhus*, it just means everybody who's listening. "So friends, just as a footprint of any living being that walks can be placed within the elephant's footprint, and so the elephant's footprint is declared the chief of them because of its great size, so too all wholesome states can be included in the Four Noble Truths. In what four? The noble truth of suffering, noble truth of the origin of suffering, the noble truth of the cessation of suffering, and the noble truth of the way leading to the cessation of suffering."

And then you get the usual definitions. It's always nice to run through them, reminders. Exactly what these things mean.

"And what is the noble truth of suffering? Well, birth is suffering. Ageing is suffering. Death is suffering. Sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief and despair are suffering." It's a lovely, nice little line. "But not to obtain what one wants is suffering. And in short, the five aggregates affected by clinging are suffering."

Now, it's the aggregates affected by clinging that are suffering, right? The aggregates themselves are not suffering. What makes them suffering is our relationship to them, which is this *upādāna*, this clinging to them, right? Come to that a bit.

"And what are the five aggregates affected by clinging? Well, they're the material form aggregate affected by clinging." That's the *rūpa*. "Feeling aggregate, affected by clinging. Perception aggregate, affected by clinging. The formations aggregate, affected by clinging." Here Bhikkhu Bodhi just translates it as formations. "Consciousness aggregate affected by clinging."

That particular *saṅkhāra* has produced wonderful things from scholars. The best one was concoctions.

Anyway, "So what is the material form aggregate affected by clinging? It is the four great elements and the material form derived from the four great elements. And what are the four great elements? They are the earth element, water element, fire element, and air element," right?

So now what we're going to do is read these elements and just see if we can actually experience them in their essential way just while we're sitting here. So the first one is the earth element. "The earth element may be either internal or external," right? So in other words, you know, if you touch the door handle, it's got some solidity.

"But what is the internal earth element? Whatever internally belonging to oneself is solid, solidified," and then you get this "clung to." So that's the relationship, but it's basically to do with solidity. "Hairs on the head, body hairs, nails, teeth, skin, flesh, sinews, bones, bone marrow, kidneys, heart, liver, diaphragm, spleen, lungs, intestines, mesentery, contents of the stomach, faeces, whatever else internally belonging to oneself is solid, solidified, and clung to. This is called the internal earth element."

So now just for a moment there if you can just get hold of that feeling of solidity. What I personally use is a knuckle. I mean, you can just feel the bone through that, you know, and it's just — so just feeling how solid bone actually is, you know. It's — yeah, just get a feel for that. So that's what it means by solid. Yeah, get a feel for it.

Yeah, are you all doing it? Are you just watching me do it? Thank you very much. It's all right watching me, but you don't get any insight from that. I'm getting all the insight.

So it's really getting hold of that and remember externally externally too — so whenever we even in the walking meditation just the way the foot hits the ground and then you feel the solidity of the ground. See, remember that's enough. That's one of these elements and you can't go beyond that. That's the understanding, you see. You can't break up the earth element into something that it's made of, right? It's a fundamental element. You might think of it as chemical elements before they discovered subatomic particles.

And it then goes on to say, "Now both the internal element and the external element are simply earth element." In other words, there's nothing else there. It's just earth element. It's the clinging that creates something of it, right? "And that it should be seen as it actually is with proper wisdom" — so this is the wisdom factor and this is what turns it into an insight process — "this is not mine, this I am not, and this is not myself."

So "this is not mine" is possession. "This I am not," that's the identity. And "this is not myself" is conceit. So every time you say "I am" and you finish the sentence, "I am unhappy," then there's a conceit there. There's a sense of who you are and you're defining it. Conceit in that broader sense of that term, right?

"Now when one sees thus as it actually is with proper wisdom, one becomes disenchanted." So there's your response to it. It's a disenchantment. You become disenchanted. In other words, you undermine that

attitude of clinging to it. So you become disenchanted with whatever is solid and makes the mind dispassionate towards the earth element. So dispassionate here, of course, means that there's no sense of clinging to it. There's no sense of loss. If you lose something that's solid, right? Come to that in a bit.

So now if we go on to the water element, we'll come back to the other stuff. We do the same thing.

"So what is the water element? The water element may be either internal or external. What is the internal water element? Whatever internally belongs to oneself is water, watery and clung to." So here he's got a wonderful list. "Bile, phlegm, pus, blood, sweat, fat, tears, grease, spittle, snot, oil in the joints, urine and whatever else is internally..."

And, of course, these contemplations can be used also to have a look at another viewpoint, which is worth a talk on its own, which is the so-called repulsiveness of the body, which is a relationship we have to it. So especially when it comes to the water element, there's very little there that we jump with delight at.

"So whatever else internally belonging to oneself is water, watery and clung to. This is called the internal water element." So just for a moment, just don't let me just do it yet. Just allow a bit of saliva to gather into your mouth and you can feel the water element. That's the water element.

Now the water element also has a sense of elasticity. Water.

"Now, both the internal water element and the external water element are simply just water elements." So, you know, it's just stressing the fact that's all it is, right? Don't put anything more on top of it. "And then it should be seen as it actually is with proper wisdom." So this is seeing things as they are, right? From a spiritual point of view, it's always about this relationship, this sense of me or mine, right? "So this is not mine," right? It's not mine. "This I am not." That's an identity. I'm not that. "And it's not myself," who I am.

"So when one sees this actually as it is, with proper wisdom," which is experiential, it's not thinking about it, it's actually doing it, "one becomes disenchanted." In other words, you don't expect anything of the water element anymore and you become dispassionate towards it. So it's neither here nor there.

Okay, that's the water element.

If we look at the fire element, it's the same thing. "So the fire element may be either internal or external, but what is the internal fire element? Whatever internally belongs to oneself is fire, fiery and clung to. And that by which one is warmed, ages and is consumed. And that by which what is eaten, drunk, consumed and tasted gets completely digested. And whatever else internally belonging to oneself is fire or fiery."

So there was a knowledge there, wasn't there, that the whole digestive system is actually creating our internal heat. And it's just, I don't know how we're going to experience that, but somewhere over there sometimes, that's if you eat a good curry and just sit there with the heat. So heat, of course, you can experience anywhere. It's just warmth, isn't it? See, my cheeks are heat at the moment. They're very hot.

So the idea of fire, something that warms. Interestingly enough, that ages. There's a connection there between fire — the burning out, the destruction of. So it's something that ages and destroys.

"So both the internal fire element and external fire element are simply just fire element. And that should be seen as it actually is with proper wisdom. It's not mine. It's not what I am. And it's not myself. And when one sees thus, actually with proper wisdom, one becomes disenchanted with the fire element and makes the mind dispassionate towards the fire element."

So remember that when you're in your rooms and you're feeling a bit cool. It's just the fire element going down. No one is actually feeling cool. But there is.

So the air element is much the same. Sometimes it's translated as wind actually. "But the air element may be either internal or external. And what is the internal element? So belonging to oneself is air, airy and clung to. Upgoing winds, downgoing winds, winds in the belly, winds in the bowels, winds that course through the limbs, in-breath and out-breath or whatever else internally belongs to oneself is air, airy and clung to. This is the internal air element."

So I don't know about winds going up and winds going down, but — we'll do the breath, shall we? We'll do the breath. Thank you. Yes. I won't worry about trying to feel the upward wind and downward wind, but definitely you can feel the breath. That's wind, the wind element. Airiness. Actually, it's just movement, isn't it? It's movement, wind element.

And that should be seen as it properly is.

So this is not mine, it's not myself, and so forth. So what one sees with proper wisdom is that you become disenchanted. Disenchanted.

So what is it we want from the world of things, the physical world? It's pleasure, isn't it? It's a pleasurable thing. And when we feel pleasurable things, we feel happy. We feel happy. That happiness can't be real in any sense of any duration, of any solidity, because when the object that's pleasant disappears, then the happiness disappears with it. And because it's clung to, you get that desire for more. We all know that.

So this disenchantment is a different way of relating to that which is pleasant in the physical world. And we don't expect anything of it. It just is. So when we eat, if it's pleasant, it's pleasant. We don't expect it to make us happy. That's the point. Although happiness may arise. And that allows us to be dispassionate towards it. In other words, when somebody says to you "let's go for a pizza" you don't jump up and down too much.

So now if we go back track a little bit, so we're back now to the earth element and we're looking at now there comes a time when the water element is disturbed and then the external element vanishes. So this is to do with the cycles of the earth where the earth is destroyed first by water then by wind and then by fire. So these are huge cyclic motions that eastern people would think much more in terms of cycles rather

than this idea of progress that we have, starting somewhere back there and we're going somewhere. And one of the great shocks of spiritual practice is to find that we're actually going nowhere.

So there's two ways of looking at time: the repetitious turning around - you know, the sun rises, the sun falls - and the idea of time moving forward. When even this external earth element, great as it is, is seen to be impermanent, subject to destruction, disappearance and change, what of this body, which is clung to by craving and lasts but a while? There can be no considering that this is I, mine or I am. So there's a connection there between the fact that these elements disappear. So it's ridiculous to have some relationship with them of identity, possession or conceit.

So now he gives an example of how this might actually manifest through personal experience. So here we have a monk who very bravely has gone amongst people who don't like him. And this is what happens to him.

If others abuse, revile, scold and harass a *bhikkhu* who has seen this element as it actually is, he understands thus: "This painful feeling, born of ear contact, has arisen in me. This is dependent, not independent. Dependent on what? Dependent on contact." Then he sees the contact is impermanent. That feeling is impermanent. Perception is impermanent. Formation is impermanent. Consciousness is impermanent. And his mind, having the element of its object supported, enters into a new objective support and acquires confidence. That's where we're going.

Then, if others attack a *bhikkhu* in ways that are unwished for, undesired and disagreeable, by contact with fists, clods, knives, sticks, he understands thus: "This body is of a nature of contact with fists, clods, sticks and knives." But this has been said by the Blessed One in his advice on the simile of the saw. This is a very famous simile: "Because if bandits were to sever you savagely limb from limb by a two-handed saw, he who gave rise to a mind of hate towards those who would carry out towards them would not be carrying out my teaching."

Once when I said this in a talk, somebody said, "Well, the Buddha had a great sense of humour."

"So tireless energy shall be aroused in me and unremitting mindfulness established. My body shall be tranquil and untroubled, my mind concentrated and unified. And now let contact with fists, clods, sticks and knives assail this body, for the teaching of the Buddhas has been practiced by me."

So remember that, yeah? The next time you're attacked, this is just a club.

And then finally, when the *Bhikkhu* then recollects the Buddha, *Dhamma*, *Sangha*, if equanimity supported by the wholesomeness does not establish in him, then he arouses a sense of urgency. This lovely sense of *samvega*, urgency: "I've got to do something about this. It is a loss for me. It is no gain for me. It is bad for me. It is no good for me. That when I thus recollect the Buddha, *Dhamma* and *Sangha*, equanimity supported by wholesomeness is not established in me."

Now we get a little bit of insight into society: "Just as when a daughter-in-law sees a father-in-law, she arouses a sense of urgency to please him, so too, when the *Bhikkhu* thus recollects the Buddha *Dhamma Sangha*, if equanimity supported by the wholesome does not become established in him, he arouses a sense of urgency. But if when he recollects the Buddha *Dhamma Sangha*, equanimity supported by wholesomeness become established in him, then he is satisfied with it. And at that point, much is done by the *Bhikkhu*."

So it's a case of also recognizing that there's a practical element of this, you know. Just people who undergo operations, losing limbs, faculties. See, this is one way that in the spiritual life they can become not so affected by it, by recognizing this body is just a vehicle.

When we've got a headache, you see, it's just the thumping in the head, pain. When you go into the pain, this is the whole thing about *vipassanā* - that you're deconstructing, going down to these *mahābhūtas*, down to these basic elements. So remember, when pain comes, physical pain, the clung to business, the *upādāna*, manifests as your relationship to it. So as soon as the pain gets to a point, you want to move. So there's an expression of your clinging, right? To this, the pain - this is my pain and I don't want it.

So you have to wait, remember, until that passes. If you don't, then you're not dealing with the clung to and it remains as a habit. It's only when you actually wait for that to pass away that this dispassion arises towards the feeling of pain in the knee. That's a direct thing. There's your dispassion. There's your equanimity with this pain in the knee.

And once that's been established, you can then go into that pain in the knee and begin to see these *Mahābhūtas*. So you go in there and the main one may be that sense of pressure, very tight, or it could be fiery, it could be very hot. So you go in there and you feel that and you point to it and you look at it and you feel it and you feel it, and there may come a reflection. You don't have to do it purposefully because just in the doing there is the seeing. But the reflection may come after the practice.

But even there, while you're doing this, you recognize that there's an observer observing, feeling, feeling these sensations, but somehow isn't it. There's a sensitivity towards them, but it's not actually identifying with it. And it's catching that, because that's your release. That's your liberation from suffering right there. It's not something mystical. You're liberating yourself from suffering, first of all, by recognizing the clung to business, which is the desire to move, which is the clung to business.

Now, when you get right down to the fire element, it's one of identity, right? So I am the body. This is me. You might say, well, intellectually we know the body, but I mean as soon as you fall ill or death approaches us we freak out. So the level of freaking out is the measure of that attachment. So these exercises really have a point to them. And after that you might reflect upon it. So when I'm here of course I ring the bell - so there's a half a minute reflection. And that's the sort of thing that you might reflect upon just for a moment.

Of course, when I'm not here, everybody jumps up and runs out. Which is not quite the practice, right? And I would suggest that you might follow that, if only out of respect for the occasional person who actually wants to do it. Because it's quite distracting, isn't it? When you're trying to reflect and you can hear this person running for it.

So it's the same with all these physical sensations that we have. When you go outside and you're walking around, and you put your eye on the ground ahead of you, and you determine that you'll just be aware of what you're hearing. So as you're going through, as you're walking around the meadows, you're hearing things. You're hearing birds, the rustle of your feet. Whatever it is. You might hear the traffic in the distance. So you're hearing, hearing, see? And then what you're trying to do is to actually begin to recognize that there's a sensation there. There's a sensation at the eardrum. It's catching something. So this is prior to actually recognising what the sound is.

So as soon as you hear the sound, of course, the mind says bird, so that you know. But the more you put yourself there, right at the ear door, then the more you're contacting that very moment when the sound comes in. Now, frankly, at that point, you don't want to be walking because you walk straight into the pond. You want to do this when you're standing.

So if you take a position at the back or somewhere to sit - which, yeah, there's only one place, I think, and that's in front of the Parinirvana Buddha. I'll try and get more. I'm not going to put seats out there. People don't put a seat. That's just for laziness, isn't it? You want to sit down for heaven's sake. But I'm hoping to put what they call, you know, in the churches where they have, they call them misery cords at the front where the monks used to sit. They used to be these, you'll see the seats, they fall down into a seat. But when you fold them up, there's a little ledge, right? So in the long chantings that they used to do, they have a rest and they would just sit a little bit on that ledge. That's why they're called pity, misery cord. These poor monks and nuns who had to chant for hours on end, you see. So I was thinking something like that, where you can sit and you can do this exercise.

And you're constantly driving yourself to the point of contact, right? Point of contact. And that's where you begin to experience these sensations. So, for instance, the hearing - you can actually experience that as a sense of touch on the eardrum. There's no sound there at all. You can actually get down to that point where all you're experiencing is like a tapping. If you were to tap your finger on the palm of your hand, it's something like that. That's all you get. And it's a drumming like that. And then it comes in.

Now that's the only point where you've got the sense base. The sense base is that basic. The next point it comes through the *manas*, which is the mental sense base. And it's at that point of *manas* that it's turned into a sound. And then the sound is worked upon and it's given a meaning. So it's a bell. And then the bell is given a meaning, wake up bell. And then right at the end of that process, you get the identity. Me, I've got to get up. That comes right at the end of that process.

And you can actually see that process, right? You might only see it once in a lifetime, but you can actually

see it. And of course, to catch these things at that level, you've really got to be really driven by interest and very, very still. You've got to be really still.

So, without being too critical, you understand, I can see that meditators are relaxing, over-relaxing. So there's got to be this constant effort. But remember, the effort is never to achieve something. It's always to maintain a certain level of interest and connection with what's actually happening here and now. And then you get these slightly deeper insights.

Is it necessary? I don't think so. I mean, they're interesting things to have. They tend to support the *Abhidhamma* and things like that. But it's not interesting and it's not important, is it? Because here in the discourse, you don't get that mincey little bit of deconstruction. You get a very straightforward sense-based deconstruction.

So, for instance, as I say, if you've got a headache, the first thing is, you just don't want it. But if you relax and relax around it, and you use that headache that we call a headache and you go into it, then you can see this tightness. There's something that constructs it. And it's just that process of disidentifying and deconstructing which is undermining this *upādāna*, this grasping. So it happens. There are many opportunities during the day when you can practice that.

And the more difficult one, of course, is when there's something which is pleasant. So obviously during mealtime, that's the time you've got to bring a certain sense of urgency, that you're not going to indulge. You're not just there to be happy. You're there to investigate the process. So that's the process of tasting. So you're trying to get down beyond the idea of what it is that you're actually eating.

I remember once at Chandoboda where often instructions weren't given so well or misconstrued by the Westerner through the process of translation and whatnot, but I asked one young fellow, I said - he came to me with a question. I said, "How are you deconstructing the whole process of eating?" He says, "Well, I eat it and I say 'yeah, that's potato' and that's..." I'm thinking, and I said, "No, no, that might make you a good cook, but couldn't get you liberated."

So it's a case of recognizing that what we're actually looking at are quite specific little sensations there, trying to get beyond the idea of the concept that comes with the taste, just to the raw tasting experience. And I'm hoping that you don't experience it once, but almost as a regular thing, that there is only taste. See, it says here, doesn't it? There is only earth element. There is only water element. There is only taste.

So what's the relationship? So you might think, "Oh, I should be joyous." So in our little verse, we say appreciative joy. Well, that might turn up, but that's not really where we're heading towards when it comes to the actual tasting process. The one is dispassion, which is a sense of equanimity. It's just tasting. And it's that point where we realize that, in fact, this is neither pleasant nor unpleasant.

And there's a sense of liberation from having to - having to try to squeeze blood out of a stone, having to try to get happiness from a piece of toast. It's like you see the stupidity of it. And then after you've

swallowed and there's a moment of rest and you turn inward, that's when you get that feeling of - not dispassion, what does he call it? Contentment, right? Another word for dispassion is contentment. That's it.

So you don't need pleasant food to make you happy. So this begins to liberate us from this idea of having to have some connection with food, undermining the connection of food with happiness. It doesn't at all undermine your sense of taste. In fact, it increases your sense of taste. I remember one person said to me that after retreat, that was the first time she'd actually ever tasted carrots. See, that was a revelation. Carrots actually have a taste. At least some do.

So it's a case of recognizing that as soon as you are seeking happiness in taste, you're already putting a concept there which is stopping you from actually experiencing the way it is, right?

So I mean, an obvious example is when you go to get a pizza or something, and there's a concept, isn't there? You've had all these pizzas in your life and you know what a pizza should taste like. Then you get this pizza and you say, "Well, this isn't a pizza." Well, it is a pizza—it's just not the pizza you'd conceptualised, not the pizza you're experiencing right now. Of course you're disappointed. "This isn't what I expected. The pastry is too thick. It's too floppy," and so on and so forth. "I didn't expect it."

So there's the product of attachment. There's the product of saying that this is mine, this is the way I want it.

So any time you come across anything physical—whether you're opening a door, closing a door, brushing your teeth, washing your face—all these are little moments of reflection. And that reflection is actually constantly helping us to form a relationship with the physical world which is no longer going to cause us any suffering. That's the point of understanding *rūpa*, form.

Very good. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance—that they have not caused even greater confusion. May you, by your sense of urgency, devote yourself to the practice. Liberate yourself sooner rather than later.

Thank you.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.